

Quince



DAVID SHAW
DECEMBER 6TH, 2025



Celebrating 22 years of Quince

Lunch Menu

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TARTELETTE

Roasted Onion Tartelette, Beet Purée, Crème Fraîche, and Tsar Nicolai Caviar

ÆBLESKIVER

Sourdough Pancake Puffs with Trout Roe and Crème Fraîche

OYSTER

Baked Tomales Bay Golden Nuggets Oyster, New Zealand Spinach, White Truffle Cream

CAVIAR

Tsar Nicolai Caviar, Honeynut Squash Tart with Herbs

PORCINI

Porcini Mushroom At Their Peak

Parmigiano Reggiano Cream with Parsley Oil, Pesto, Raw Porcini Slices, Nuts, Sformato of Porcini

— CHEF’S TABLE —

LOBSTER

*Catalina Spiny Lobster with Hakurei Turnip, Swiss Chard Cream and Its Oil, Persimmon, and Sabayon
Bordelaise with Cubed Hakurei Turnip and Lobster*

FAGOTTINI DI FONDUTA AL TARTUFO BIANCO

Fagottini with Fontal and Fontina Cheese, Alba White Truffle

TAJARIN ‘40 YOLKS’ AL TARTUFO BIANCO

With Alba White Truffle

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SQUAB

*Squab Legs from Paine Farm Grilled on Binchōtan
Served With green farro, Beet, Black Trumpet Mushroom, and Chanterelle Purée
a Squab Jus with Pomegranate and Hibiscus*

Radicchio Salad with Pomegranate

Brioche with Cultured Butter and Herb Oil

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BONET ALLA PIEMONTESE

*Warm Custard of Chocolate and Amaretti Cookies, Cocoa Nibs, Chestnut Gelato, Roasted Quince,
Crispy Leaves in the Flavors of Chestnut, Quince, and Cocoa*

WHITE TRUFFLE

*Housemade Waffle Cone with Candied Hazelnut,
White Truffle Gelato, and Cocoa Nibs Cream*

MIGNARDISE CART

Eggnog Bonbon, Concord Grape Bonbon, Hazelnut Praline, Mulled Wine Pâte de Fruit

FAREWELL DRINK



Traveling from Los Angeles to San Francisco, the lingering heat of the southern region finally yields to the chill, gentle zephyr of the north, carrying with it a quiet consolation I cannot help but associate with the Christmas season. Walking toward Quince, I pass through a neighborhood that is at once elegant and alive, the streets dotted with diners lingering over midday meals at curbside tables, a scene both refined and vivid. I cross the street and arrive at the door of the restaurant, its understated entrance promising something quietly exceptional within. Stepping across the threshold, I am immediately embraced by an atmosphere both relaxed and refined, cozy yet unmistakably elegant, imbued with the subtle magic of the holidays. A cast-iron bench is placed with deliberate charm and cozy intimacy, while several Christmas trees stand in staggered layers, their carefully placed ornaments and lights conjuring a scene of picturesque whimsy, a fleeting glimpse of a fairyland brought to life indoors.

A routine check-in unfolds, the kind I have experienced hundreds of times at other fine dining establishments, and I am smoothly ushered to the bar, where only three seats are arranged, intimate and deliberate. It is here, at this graceful counter, that the first hints of magic emerge. A gentleman appears, clad in a uniformed yet effortlessly elegant avocado-green suit, greeting me with words of genuine warmth that acknowledge my choice to dress formally for the occasion. In that instant, the restaurant's nobility becomes apparent, for while their dress code is strict, there is no trace of pretentious condescension, only gratitude toward guests who honor it. I feel a quiet satisfaction in having dressed with care, even for a lunch that might otherwise have seemed less formal, little realizing then that this choice would soon open the door to yet more enchanting rewards and magic.

I admit I had been nursing a quiet anxiety along the way, fearing the lighting at the bar might be dim, for at Quince a solo diner is placed at the counter rather than the sun-drenched sanctuary of the main dining room. Yet, that unease vanished the moment I arrived, for this counter revealed itself to be the restaurant's crowning jewel: a space at once open and profoundly private. An entire wall of French paintings lends the space a sublime elegance, commanding the room with a quiet yet undeniable grandeur. Most satisfyingly, I found myself blissfully accompanied by two gentlemen who are at once bartenders and servers, their composed and graceful presence wrapping me in a sense of profound well-being.



Seated at the bar, I am captivated by the elegant movements of the two gentlemen before me, shaking and stirring and pouring, in a series of suave movements. They craft one fabulous drink after another to be whisked away to other guests, yet I alone am granted the privilege of witnessing their birth, as if I am witnessing them in the very womb of life itself.

Soon I am asked whether I would like a glass for myself, an offer I gently decline. Tap water will do just fine, I say. A similar question follows regarding the food, as the lunch menu is a shortened version of the restaurant's full tasting experience. Offered only on Fridays and Saturdays, a curated seven-course menu presents itself as a measured and leisurely offering, one that feels entirely sufficient for a midday escape for me. Out of a desire to preserve simplicity, I choose not to add any supplemental courses. I keep the experience deliberately unembellished, declining even the celebrated caviar dish that has long been the staple on the menu before the grandiose renovation of the restaurant two years ago. In doing so, I allow myself to encounter hospitality in its purest form, one not heightened by the act of spending more, but revealed through attentiveness, generosity, and the quiet confidence of a restaurant that has nothing to prove.

With decisions settled, the tasting journey quietly sets itself in motion, and before I am fully aware of the transition, two amuse-bouches are placed before me. One takes the form of a roasted onion tartelette, crowned with Tsar Nicolai caviar and dotted with beet purée and crème fraîche; the other, a charming sourdough æbleskiver, is filled with trout roe and crème fraîche. The fan-pleated disc of roasted onion is an artwork on its own, astonishingly light in structure yet deeply expressive in flavor, and as I lift it to my mouth, a bomb of mellow sweetness explodes, layered with savory depth and a lingering, nutty warmth. Only afterward does the caviar assert itself, a restrained oceanic umami that settles gently into the onion base, recalling the harmony of a classic caviar service with blinis.

The æbleskiver, by contrast, exhibits itself through texture first as the airy puff of sourdough encloses the richness of trout roe and cream within. Upon biting, the experience unfolds in two stages, the initial collapse of the warm puff followed by the delicate pop of the individual roes, releasing their briny brightness in succession. It is difficult not to notice that both compositions are guided by a shared logic, each built around a core of roe and cream, supported by a glutenous base, and while the textural expressions diverge markedly, their flavor profiles converge in a way that feels meticulously composed. The result is undeniably comforting and elegantly executed, though free of surprise, offering nostalgic reassurance more than provocation.





The first course listed on the menu revealed itself to be an oyster dish, presented in its own shell, baked and served with spinach and a frothy white truffle cream. The oyster itself, the Golden Nugget oyster, is a specific, premium variety from Tomales Bay Oyster Company in California, known for the rich, buttery flavor with hints of melon and cucumber, created by unique tumbling in the bay's currents. Yet once baked, its nuanced flavor faded, and the lavish white truffle cream spilled over the petite bivalve like a molten blanket, overwhelming what made it distinctive. The spinach on the other hand lends a welcome counterpoint, offering a touch of green bitterness to steady the richness. It is an aromatic, typical old-school composition, one that would benefit from a lighter, more restrained hand.



By this point, a certain ennui had set in at the fine edge of the chef's repeated use of caviar and roe. So as the true caviar course arrives — a halved honeynut squash tart crowned with Tsar Nicolai caviar — the sense of magic has already softened. Still, the dish reveals itself as simple yet refined. The dual textures of the honeynut squash dispels any suspicion of monotony: the slices offer hydration and delicacy, while the purée beneath is creamier, richer in its natural sweetness. The caviar, perched on top, tempered the squash's otherwise singular note, introducing a playful contrast of texture and a welcome trace of oceanic brightness.



When I find myself waiting for the next courses, I pause and simply gaze at the bar, watching the various drinks curated by the bartenders, whose esoteric movements suggest thought and contemplation.

There are two bartenders performing at the bar, and at this moment, my observation grants me a clearer image of them. The elder one, lean and tall, carries such an elegant temperament that I easily associate him with MI6 Chief Atlee from the Mission Impossible film; the other, chubby and jovial, more closely resembles FBI agent Carl from Catch Me If You Can. Notably, he is the same gentleman who appreciated my suit earlier.

What follows is a celebration of the porcini mushroom. At the center rests a medallion of sformato, the Italian cousin of flan, made from porcini and topped with raw slices of the mushroom and some refreshing pesto. Surrounding it is a Parmigiano Reggiano cream, medleyed with parsley oil. The sformato carries an almost unbearable lightness, velvety in texture, allowing the porcini's deep, earthy aroma to shine through completely. The raw slices, on the other hand, lean toward nuttiness and delicate umami, revealing the mushroom's more enchanting nuances. The pesto and nuts accent the porcini with an added layer of freshness, while the Parmigiano Reggiano cream, vibrant and expansive, delivers a passionate flourish without overpowering the mushroom in the slightest. This winter treasure, at the peak of its season, has been whimsically transformed into a dish that feels both timelessly classical and quietly innovative, one I will remember for a long time.

The chubby gentleman is at the bar most of the time and does most of the talking with me. By this point, we are getting to know each other better. He kindly inquires about my reason for visiting San Francisco, and I mention that I was celebrating my two-hundredth Michelin star at Kiln, which impresses him. Yet little do I know at this moment that a big surprise is waiting for me very soon.





Just as I am waiting for the next course, a lady of the maître d' kind approaches me and kindly asks me to follow her into the kitchen for a tour. Such an invitation feels nothing out of the ordinary, for I have been led into kitchens dozens of times. Yet it is only when I step inside that I notice a tiny table draped in white cloth, with a small bouquet arranged just for me. Apparently, I am to enjoy the next course inside the kitchen. Now this is something special. A kitchen table experience is a rarity, and in certain restaurants it can cost quite a lot simply to be immersed in the heart of the action. I feel specially taken care of, how sweet.

The kitchen at Quince is rather restrained. I am seated at the very center of the kitchen, almost as if I might obstruct the brigade's movements, yet so finely trained are they that my presence causes not the slightest disruption. Beside my table is something phenomenal, a giant open-fire stove — a touch of wildness within this otherwise refined space. The chef supervising the kitchen today, the chef de cuisine, is a serious man. He greets me and presents the next dish, a French-style lobster course. At the center rests a fine cut of Catalina spiny lobster medallion, accompanied by a sabayon, a slice of persimmon, and finely chopped Swiss chard with its own oil. He then finishes the plate with a Bordelaise sauce and cubes of Hakurei turnip. The addition of persimmon is both unusual and intriguing; the rest of the composition feels resolutely classical, something one might expect at Umberto Bombana's restaurant. I find myself wondering why a traditional French dish sits so comfortably at the heart of an Italian menu, though perhaps the close kinship between the two cuisines offers its own explanation.





A main course at the kitchen table is a blessing in itself, yet the restaurant has another surprise in store. The executive chef and owner, Michael Tusk, appears to greet me with such tenderness. Dressed in a navy-blue apron, he carries himself with an easy warmth. From a corner station, he retrieves a wooden board crowned with a glass cloche, its handle fashioned from oxhorn. Beneath it rest two magnificent white truffles from Alba. As he approaches, he lifts the cloche and invites me to inhale. It is not my first encounter with this treasure, yet one can never tire of its perfume. My mind races to decipher the reason for this gesture. I dare not presume too much, and assume he is simply indulging in a proud display of winter's bounty. Then a plate of Fagottini di Fonduta is set before me — a compliment from the chef, how surprising! Better still, he reaches for a truffle shaver and, with the flourish of a wizard, begins to shower the pasta in white truffle. Just as I think he might stop, he continues, and continues, until the fagottini disappear beneath a snowfall of ivory. I sit there, almost speechless at the generosity of it all.



Hardly has the last of those delicate envelopes vanished when a second offering arrives — Tajarin, a slender, lesser-known ribbon of gold. This time, the truffle is shaved by a waiter, whose hand, as expected, is considerably more tempered than the chef's. The shavings may carry a practiced restraint, yet the fragrance remains intoxicating. As the truffle settles on the tajarin, I feel a profound sense of gratitude for this unexpected encore.

The fagottini, encapsulating an almost liquid mélange of Fontal and Fontina, offers little beyond the buttery, nutty notes of these cow's milk cheeses, allowing purity itself to work its quiet magic. Tajarin, the emblematic pasta of Piedmont, particularly the Langhe and Monferrato, is defined by its lavish ratio of egg yolks to flour. Here, the recipe calls for as many as 40 yolks per kilogram of flour, rendering the gold ribbon exceptionally rich. That opulent yolk intensity is, in turn, sublimated by the white truffle, lifted to a realm that feels almost unimaginable. Both pasta dishes present themselves in their simplest form: swiftly poached in boiling water, glossed with emulsified pasta water, and finished with truffle shavings. Yet it is precisely this simplicity that amplifies the elemental magic of pasta and truffle in union.





Returning to the bar from the kitchen, I see my old friend again, the chubby gentleman. I recount the magnificent moments I have just experienced, and he nods with a knowing smile. The journey of collecting two hundred Michelin stars is truly monumental, after all, he says. It becomes clear to me then that I have him to thank for the kitchen rendezvous. Interestingly enough, he seems genuinely surprised that the chef has sent out two pasta dishes. One, he implies, would have been within expectation; two are almost unheard of. At the beginning of the meal, I had noticed a section on the menu listing special add-ons, and each of the pastas I had in the kitchen is priced at \$150. The fact that they were offered as compliments makes the gesture all the more extraordinary. Soon, the chef comes out from the kitchen once more to greet me kindly, sealing the kitchen table experience as something not performative, but sincerely heartfelt.

As I settle back at the bar, the buoyant energy of the kitchen still lingering, a series of elements begins to assemble before me: a brioche bun accompanied by a fancy dish of butter adorned with blossoms and herb oil; an elegant saucepan poised over a tiny candle stove; and a pair of cutlery unlike any I have seen before, which I later learn to be crafted by Everett Noel, a local artisan from the Sierra Foothills. A wooden serving table is then wheeled to my side, unveiling the final savory course with a unique bar-side presentation that feels both theatrical and intimate. Earlier in the kitchen, seated at my small table and observing the brigade's assured choreography, I had noticed a young chef tending the charcoal grill alone. From my vantage point, I watched him brush oil and sauce onto several squabs resting over the Binchōtan grill, coaxing them toward perfect tenderness. That memory now resolves itself on the serving table before me. The chubby gentleman proceeds to carve the two legs tableside, preserving a generous, boneless thigh at the center of the plate while arranging the drumstick and claw with deliberate care. Even half of the head is presented alongside, a gesture I find worthy of praise, though perhaps a daring flourish for the more traditional, old-money diners of this establishment.





On the plate, the squab legs rest on top of a bed of green farro, encircled by a demi-lune of beet, a black trumpet mushroom, a chanterelle purée, and, of course, the bird's own head. The small saucepan is then opened to reveal a squab jus infused with pomegranate and hibiscus, which is poured over the composition as a final, crowning gloss. Alongside arrives a generous bowl of radicchio salad studded with pomegranate seeds, presented almost as a dish unto itself, its portion ample enough to stand alone on an American diner's menu.

The presence of farro and radicchio gestures toward an allegiance to Italian culinary tradition, yet the presentation and preparation of the squab suggest a modern French, even New American, inflection. Grilled over Binchōtan, the bird carries a refined smokiness, ensuring a measured note of wildness woven into its flesh. Compared with restaurants such as Birdsong, where the embrace of charcoal can verge on assertive, the handling here is more restrained, resulting in a refined balance that harmonizes effortlessly with the elegant garnishes.

The intensity of the early-harvest green farro is showcased through its pronounced nutty, smoky, and earthy notes, flavors that sing in quiet harmony with the squab. Its firm, chewy texture, with a hint of crunch, provides a sturdy, grounding counterpoint to the tenderness of the bird. On its own, the grain may feel slightly austere, even a touch too harsh, but once enveloped in the jus and silken purée, the composition comes fully into focus. The result is both sumptuous and substantial, precisely the kind of presence one expects from a main course.



By this point, the chubby gentleman has answered a torrent of questions about the ingredients and their sourcing. When the main dish is served, he even takes the initiative to ask whether I have further inquiries, a gesture that leaves me deeply appreciative of both his knowledge and his attentiveness. I tell him that in the past, I have often received the polite but perfunctory answers that a detailed menu would be presented at the end of the meal but only to find those notes insufficiently illuminating. His willingness to elaborate, I state, is something I genuinely value. With a smile, he replies that it is precisely my curiosity that invites such answers; it is clear to him, he says, that I truly care about food and wish to understand it more deeply.



As our conversation gently tapers off, the cadence of the meal shifts once more. The weight of the savory courses lifts, and the tabletop is reset for something gentler, a softer rhythm of falling leaves unfolding as the first dessert appears. On the plate, an artful arrangement of autumn leaves rests as if naturally fallen, their forms strikingly lifelike and delicate, their hues shifting in quiet gradation from deep maroon to pale ivory. Gently parting the foliage reveals the true centerpiece of the composition — Bonet alla Piemontese.

While this traditional Piedmontese dessert is typically defined by a dense, potent profile, this rendition offers a lighter body. Gone is the customary density, the emphatic notes of caramel and dark chocolate. In its place arrives a warm custard that leans more toward the fragrance of amaretti cookies and amaretto that are airier in expression, yet imbued with a gentle, enveloping warmth. Encircling the custard are cocoa nibs, chestnut gelato, and roasted quince, each contributing a distinct autumn-winter accent. Together they weave a tapestry of flavors at once seasonal and nuanced, layering texture and aroma with quiet sophistication. Even the leaves themselves prove much more than ornamental, they are themselves infused with the flavors of chestnut, quince, and cocoa. One cannot help but marvel at the pastry chef's ingenuity and the sheer finesse of execution required to harmonize such delicate artistry with such soulful flavors.



Just as I am still marveling at the treasures woven into the dessert, another petite indulgence arrives, showcasing a final gesture of capturing the essence of winter and, unmistakably, calls back to my time in the kitchen. Rising from a bowl of cocoa nib soil stands a housemade waffle cone, its rim powdered with candied hazelnut, its body filled with white truffle gelato and cocoa nib cream. I had not expected white truffle to draw me once more into its quiet decadence after leaving the kitchen, yet here it returns, unapologetically. Small in stature though it may be, its impact is anything but restrained. A tsunami of earthy perfume — that unmistakable signature of white truffle — sweeps across the palate, unfolding with dramatic intensity. I am left momentarily speechless, surrendering once again to its extravagant allure.



On my way to the kitchen earlier, a flamboyant petit fours trolley caught my attention, and at the end of lunch, it finally wheels over to me. A trolley is something I might easily take for granted at a grand formal French restaurant like Robuchon au Dôme. Yet at a niche bar lunch like this, the trolley feels like a true reward. By this end of the meal I am already overwhelmed by the array of amazing dishes, whose portions far exceed my expectations. I therefore choose only four pieces that I feel will offer flavors I may have never savored before: the eggnog bonbon, concord grape bonbon, hazelnut praline, and mulled wine pâte de fruit.

The eggnog bonbon carries such a depth that is beyond imagination — a not-to-miss indulgence that fits the Christmas season so harmoniously. The concord grape showcases the same depth but of dark fruit, and further with a concentrated aroma and refined mellowness. Beyond their flavors, both bonbons are crafted with remarkable finesse, an extremely light texture and delicacy that amplified the full potential of what they held. The hazelnut praline offers a contrasting texture that could be described as toffee-like chewiness paired with ganache-like tenderness, along with an exuberant nuttiness that again suits the season perfectly. Finally, a staple pâte de fruit of mulled wine concludes the trolley’s magic show with its warm, cozy, and comforting profile — blending red wine, aromatic holiday spices, and citrus — landing on yet another festive note.



The chubby gentleman makes sure the final bite of the mignardise has been carefully savored in my mouth before he tries to fetch the bill, which he soon realizes is in vain, as the whole experience has been prepaid online. He gives me a polite smile to cover his awkwardness, which I find only adds a comedic touch to his elegance. He then mentions that a farewell drink shall be offered to guests to counter the chilly weather outside. In these circumstances, I find this gesture even more considerate than a take-home gift. He provides two options, a turmeric ginger based healthy tea or a hot chocolate, to which I provide no answer but simply leave the choice to him. Sensing the trust cast upon him, he runs to the kitchen like an excited kid granted a special task. On my way out, I again show my gratitude to the two gentlemen who assisted me throughout the lunch service. Standing in the piercing wind, I take a sip of the drink — hot tea, indeed. I feel the warmth spread throughout my body as I pace away from the restaurant.